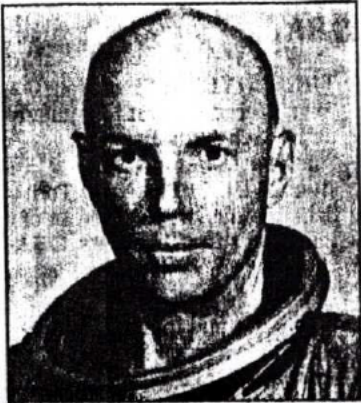


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NASA photo

Story Musgrave, a member of NASA's "A-team," became an astronaut in 1967.

He's ready for a close encounter

By DAN FELDSTEIN
OF THE HOUSTON POST STAFF

Don't be alarmed, but one of four astronauts who will spacewalk to fix the Hubble Space Telescope hopes to see aliens.

"I try to communicate with the life that's out there. I'm serious. It is not that far out," says Story Musgrave.

"When I'm circling around out there, I try in whatever ways I can to get them to come down here and get me."

That's not just a good sense of humor. He means it.

It fits neatly in the personality of a man who has been an astronaut since 1967, has at least six college degrees and takes every class he can find at University of Houston-Clear Lake purely for fun.

Musgrave, 58, is the senior member of the seven-member crew set to launch today on a space shuttle mission to repair the blurry Hubble.

All are veteran space fliers, and some at the space agency

have called them the "A Team" — an all-star cast for a critical mission.

Musgrave said his astronaut training started as a five-year-old boy fixing his tractor in Berkshire County, Mass. After high school he joined the Marines and eventually became a pilot.

Then there are his degrees: a bachelor's in math and statistics from Syracuse, an MBA from UCLA, a bachelor's in chemistry from Marietta College, a doctor of medicine from Columbia, a master's in physiology and biophysics from the University of Kentucky.

Those are just the ones he got before becoming an astronaut.

In a stroke of great fortune for Musgrave, NASA opened the astronaut corps to non-test pilot scientists in 1964. All his degrees

suddenly made sense and he was accepted into the program a few years later.

Musgrave served as backup scientist-pilot for the first Skylab mission in 1973. He helped design the spacesuits and spacewalking system now used on the shuttle.

In 1983, on the sixth space shuttle flight, Musgrave got his first ride in space and took the first spacewalk from a shuttle.

Physically fit and shiny bald, Musgrave loves parachuting, soaring and walking around downtown Houston looking at buildings. He is twice divorced and has five children ranging in age from 6 to 32.

His top recreation is taking literature and philosophy classes at UH-Clear Lake. He earned his master's in literature in 1987 and hints that there are other degrees he doesn't bother to put on his

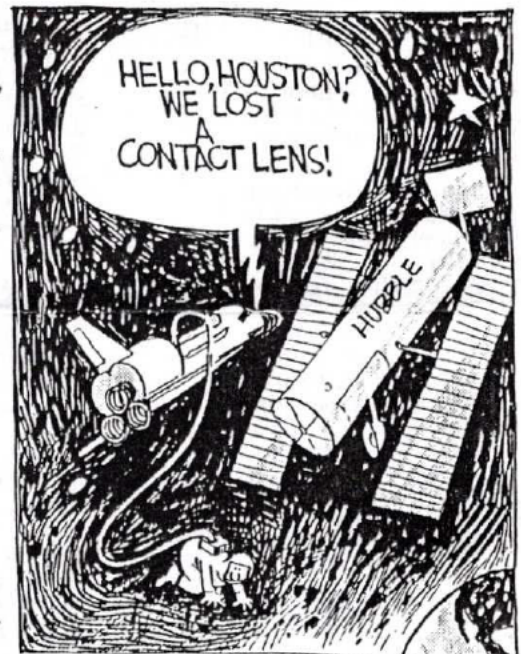
resume.

As payload commander for the Hubble flight, Musgrave will set a number of records. He will be the world's oldest spacewalker, the first astronaut on five shuttle flights and should set the record for time in orbit on a shuttle — 361 hours.

After the flight, he'll look forward to more.

"I love space and I love the space business. There's no way I can conceive of walking away. I'm gonna die on the job probably, one way or the other," he said.

"You know, the night before a launch, I go down and I lie by the ocean down there and look at the stars and I see some satellites overhead and I think, 'Tomorrow you're going to be one of those. See that streak? That's you tomorrow.'"



BY JOHN F. SCHUESSLER